tea with almost half a dozen couples, now all Israeli citizens. The visit was just after Diwali, so Veena (whose idea it was) had carried some traditional Marathi Diwali sweets. These couples were very happy to speak in Marathi and hear about Pune and were touched by our gesture. Mr Yaron Mayer, who I had befriended during my DA tenure in Myanmar, was also similarly located and we went to visit him and his wife at their kibbutz near Tel Aviv, thereby getting a feel of a kibbutz too.

As a young subaltern, my uncle, Maj Gen AS Naravane, had fought in the North African Campaign and had been taken Prisoner of War (PW), when their gun position had been overrun by the Germans. They had been housed at the POW camp at Averse in Italy. He had written in his memoirs (*A Soldier's Life in War and Peace*) how they had escaped from that camp and been sheltered by a local Italian family. Once again with the help of the DA, Col Rohit Teotia, we were able to track down Ms Mena Fatato, the granddaughter of that gentleman. When we went to Cassino to inaugurate the Indian Army War Memorial, we met the lady and I presented her with a copy of my uncle's book. The lady and her husband were moved to tears, that over seventy years later we had reached out to them. More than my meeting with the Italian Chief, Lt Gen Pietro Serino, or the Defence Minister Lorenzo Guerini in Rome, it is this meeting that made the headlines in the local press. Unfortunately, towards the end of the visit, Veena tested Covid-positive during the pre-departure testing and had to remain behind in Rome while the rest of the delegation returned as scheduled. It was a difficult but unavoidable decision. It would be more than two weeks before Veena could travel again, so she had a 'Roman Holiday' of sorts.

During the visit to the United Kingdom, I inspected the Guard of Honour provided by the Grenadier Guards on Horse

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